Ita Wegman and Rudolf Steiner

A Working Partnership at the Origins of Anthroposophical Medicine

Ita Wegman and Rudolf Steiner had one of the most significant working relationships in the history of Anthroposophy, centered above all on the founding of anthroposophical medicine.

A Physician Meets a Spiritual Teacher

Wegman (1876–1943) was a Dutch physician, born in Java in the Dutch East Indies, who trained in medicine in Zurich at a time when it was still unusual for women to do so. She first encountered Steiner's work in the early years of the twentieth century and became a student of his spiritual-scientific teachings, but unlike most of his followers she brought a fully qualified medical background to the relationship. That combination—a trained doctor deeply committed to Steiner's worldview—made her uniquely positioned to translate his ideas about the human being into clinical practice.

The Clinic in Arlesheim

Their collaboration took concrete form in 1921, when Wegman founded the Clinical-Therapeutic Institute in Arlesheim, Switzerland, near the Goetheanum. This was the first clinic to put anthroposophical medical ideas into practice, and it still exists today (long known as the Ita Wegman Clinic, now part of Klinik Arlesheim). It was also there that she helped develop the mistletoe-based cancer therapy that Steiner had suggested, which became one of anthroposophical medicine's most well-known contributions.

Fundamentals of Therapy (1925)

The intellectual high point of their partnership was the book they wrote together, usually translated as Fundamentals of Therapy (originally "Grundlegendes für eine Erweiterung der Heilkunst nach geisteswissenschaftlichen Erkenntnissen"), published in 1925. This was Steiner's last book, co-authored with Wegman while he was already in declining health, and it remains the foundational text of the field. The fact that Steiner chose to write his final work jointly with her—rather than alone, as with nearly everything else—says a great deal about the trust and creative closeness between them.

Leadership in the Anthroposophical Society

Their relationship also had an organizational dimension. When Steiner refounded the Anthroposophical Society at the Christmas Conference of 1923–24, he established a School of Spiritual Science with various specialized sections, and he placed Wegman at the head of its Medical Section. She was also named to the Society's governing Executive Council (the Vorstand), making her one of the small circle of people Steiner entrusted with leading the movement.

Steiner’s Final Months

In Steiner’s final months she served as his attending physician. He fell seriously ill in the autumn of 1924 and died on 30 March 1925, with Wegman caring for him through that period.

Karmic Connection and Later Conflict

Two further things are worth mentioning. First, Steiner spoke—in the esoteric register that characterized much of his late teaching—of a karmic connection between the two of them said to reach back across earlier lifetimes; this idea has considerable weight within anthroposophical circles, though it belongs to the movement’s spiritual self-understanding rather than to documented history.

Second, the closeness of their bond became a source of tension after his death. Disputes within the Society, partly bound up with rivalries among Steiner’s close collaborators, led to a bitter schism, and in 1935 Wegman was actually expelled from the Anthroposophical Society—a decision later regarded by many as a grave injustice. She continued her medical and curative work until her death in 1943.